Leadership in Youth-Led NGOs

Roles, Responsibilities & Ethics

Youth Advocate Network Rwanda | Capacity Building Program

What We'll Cover Today

1. Leadership vs Management - Understanding the difference
2. Organizational Structure - Board, Executive, Members
3. Core Leadership Responsibilities
4. Ethical Leadership Principles
5. Communication & Public Speaking
6. Facilitation & Conflict Resolution

Leadership vs Management

Understanding the Critical Difference

LEADERSHIP

- Setting the vision
- Inspiring people
- Creating change
- Innovation & growth
- Long-term direction

FOCUS:
"Doing the RIGHT things"

MANAGEMENT

- Planning & organizing
- Coordinating resources
- Implementing systems
- Monitoring progress
- Day-to-day operations

FOCUS:
"Doing things RIGHT"

Why Youth-Led NGOs Need BOTH

Leadership Only

Leadership without Management = Great ideas that never happen

Management Only

Management without Leadership = Efficiently doing the wrong things

REAL IMPACT

Key Insight: Start with passion (leadership), but develop skills to execute (management). Great organizations do both.

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Understanding Your NGO Structure

Board vs Executive Team vs Members

BOARD OF DIRECTORS

GOVERNANCE

- Set vision & mission
- Approve budgets & plans
- Hire/evaluate ED
- Ensure legal compliance
- Fundraising support

EXECUTIVE TEAM

OPERATIONS

- Implement strategy
- Manage programs
- Lead staff/ volunteers
- Report to Board
- Community engagement

MEMBERS

PARTICIPATION

- Participate in programs
- Provide feedback
- Volunteer time
- Attend meetings
- Elect Board members

Why Separation of Powers Matters

Common Mistake: Same people on Board & Executive = conflicts of interest!

BOARD

Governs & oversees
Sets vision & policy
Evaluates leadership

→

EXECUTIVE

Implements strategy
Manages programs
Reports to Board

→

MEMBERS

Participate & benefit
Elect Board members
Provide feedback

Like government: Board = Parliament (makes laws) | Executive = Cabinet (implements laws)

Core Leadership Responsibilities

What Every Youth Leader Must Master

1. Setting & Communicating Vision

1. **Develop together** : Co-create with your team, don’t impose it alone
2. **Communicate constantly** : Repeat in every meeting, report, and conversation
3. **Make it real** : Every project must connect back to your vision
4. **Adapt intentionally** : Vision can evolve, but changes must be deliberate

Practical Exercise: Know Your structure & Values

Part A: Structure Check (5 minutes)

Draw a simple diagram of your current (or ideal) NGO structure.

- Who is on the Board? (Governance)
- Who is on the Executive Team? (Operations)
- Where are your Members/Volunteers?

Part B: Values Check (5 minutes)

Write down your answers:

1. One leadership strength I have (related to communication, vision, or integrity):
   _____
2. One leadership skill I need to improve (based on today's topics):
   _____

2. Ensuring Accountability

Accountability = everyone owns their commitments — including you as the leader.

Members & Beneficiaries
Programs deliver real impact
Listen to community needs

Funders & Donors
Use funds as promised
Report real impact, not just activity

Your Team
Fair treatment & clear expectations
Recognize every contribution

Law & Society
Follow Rwanda's NGO regulations
Ethical practices, always

3. Team Coordination & Support

Keep volunteers motivated, organized, and productive

Clear Role Definitions
Write simple job descriptions — even for volunteers

Regular Check-ins
Weekly syncs keep everyone aligned and problems caught early

Recognize Contributions
Certificates, shout-outs, thank-you notes — they matter

Grow Your People
Mentorship, training, leadership roles — invest in your team

4. Representation & Advocacy

As a youth leader, you are the VOICE of your organization. This is a serious responsibility.

🎤 WHEN REPRESENTING

📊 **Know Your Facts**
Research issues thoroughly before speaking

❤️ **Stay Authentic**
Share real stories, not just statistics

👔 **Be Professional**
Arrive on time, follow up on commitments

🤝 **Consult Your Team**
Your positions must reflect the group

📍 WHERE YOU REPRESENT

🏛️ **Government**
Ministry consultations, policy dialogues

📺 **Media**
TV, radio, newspapers, social media

🌐 **Donor Events**
Conferences, workshops, networking

🏫 **Community**
Schools, youth forums, local gatherings

Ethical Leadership

The Foundation of Trust

Integrity: Walking the Talk

Your ACTIONS must match your WORDS — always.

Late Report

Funder report due, activities incomplete

❌ Exaggerate

✅ **Be honest about delays**

Friend's Request

Friend applies — not most qualified

❌ Hire them anyway

✅ **Fair hiring process**

Leftover Funds

Unspent project budget, board not watching

❌ Personal use

✅ **Consult board, reallocate**

Managing Conflict of Interest

When personal interests could influence organizational decisions — disclose & manage.

COMMON EXAMPLES IN YOUTH NGOs

- Family company bids for NGO contract
- Paid consultancy competing with NGO work
- Romantic relationship: supervisor + volunteer
- Using NGO equipment for personal business

HOW TO HANDLE IT

1. **DISCLOSE**
   Tell your Board immediately
2. **RECUSE**
   Step away from that decision
3. **DOCUMENT**
   Keep a written record

Hiding conflicts destroys trust. Disclosing them builds it.

Safeguarding: Protecting Those You Serve

🚨 **THIS IS NON-NEGOTIABLE — Every youth NGO MUST have safeguarding policies**

🔍 **Background Checks**
Criminal record checks for all staff working with children

📜 **Code of Conduct**
No private meetings with minors; no exploitative relationships

📣 **Reporting Mechanism**
Anonymous reporting available — investigate every report

🎓 **Training**
All staff trained to recognize and report abuse

📸 **Photo/Media Consent**
Written permission before photographing minors

Ethical Use of Resources

Every franc, every hour — belongs to the MISSION, not you personally.

Financial Transparency

Detailed records of all income/expenses
Board financial reports every quarter
Approval required for large expenditures
Never mix personal & NGO money

Asset Management

Maintain inventory of all NGO property
NGO equipment = NGO use only
Clear procedures for borrowing items
Report damaged or lost items immediately

Time & Effort

If funded for 20 hrs/week — give 20 hrs
No ghost workers on project reports
Track time honestly
Deliver quality, not just attendance

Authority vs Leadership

Position alone doesn't make you a leader

⚔️ AUTHORITY

Given by position/title
People follow because they HAVE TO
Based on power
Commands compliance
Fear-based motivation

"Do this because I'm the Executive Director."

🌟 LEADERSHIP

Earned through respect
People follow because they WANT TO
Based on trust
Inspires commitment
Purpose-driven motivation

"Let's do this to reach our shared vision."

Personal Values & Self-Awareness

Great leaders know their strengths, weaknesses, triggers, and what they truly value.

💡 *Keep a leadership journal — weekly reflections build self-aareness over time.*

💡 What are my core values?

⚡ What triggers me & how do I prepare?

🌟 What are my natural leadership strengths?

📈 What skills do I still need to develop?

🎯 Am I leading for ego, or the mission?

👂 Do I listen more than I talk?

Effective Communication & Public Speaking

Core Communication Principles

🎯 **Know Your Audience**
Adapt language — data for officials, stories for youth

✂️ **Be Clear & Concise**
One clear message beats five complex ones

👂 **Listen First**
50% of communication is listening — ask questions first

📖 **Use Stories**
Stats inform. Stories persuade. Use both.

🤲 **Body Language Matters**
Eye contact, posture & gestures speak as loud as words

📝 **Follow Up in Writing**
A written summary confirms understanding & accountability

Public Speaking Mastery

📋 BEFORE YOUR SPEECH

- 🎯 3 key messages maximum
- 📢 Practice out loud 3 times
- ❓ Prepare for likely questions
- 👗 Dress professionally & comfortably
- 🏛️ Visit the venue if possible

🎤 DURING YOUR SPEECH

- 🪝 Start with a hook — question, story, or fact
- 🐢 Speak slowly; pause between points
- 👀 Make eye contact across the room
- 🤚 Use natural hand gestures
- 📣 End with a clear call to action

Managing Public Speaking Nerves

Everyone gets nervous. The difference? They know how to manage it.

1. **Reframe It**
   Nervousness = excitement. Say “I’m excited” instead of “I’m scared.”

2. **Breathe Deeply**
   3 slow breaths: in through nose (4 counts), out through mouth (6 counts).

3. **Focus on Them**
   Ask “How can I help them?” — not “What will they think of me?”

4. **Start Strong**
   Memorize your opening line. Nail it and confidence flows naturally.

5. **Accept Imperfection**
   Pause, smile, continue. Audiences forgive authenticity.

Facilitation & Group Dialogue

Leading Productive Conversations

What Makes a Good Facilitator?

A facilitator is a GUIDE — help the group think together, not for them.

Create Safe Space
Ground rules: respect, confidentiality, one speaker at a time

Draw Out Quiet Voices
“We haven’t heard from you yet — any thoughts?”

Stay Neutral
Help THEM reach conclusions — don’t impose yours

Watch the Time
Keep on track; if running over, ask the group

Ask Open Questions
“What do you think about...?” not “Do you agree?”

Manage Dominant Talkers
“Thanks — let’s hear other perspectives now.”

Summarize & Synthesize
“I’m hearing three main themes...” Help group see patterns

End with Action
“What are our next steps? Who’s responsible?”

Conflict Resolution

Conflict is NORMAL — the question is how you handle it.

Step 1 | Listen to Both Sides
Meet separately. Listen without judgment.

Step 2 | Identify Real Issue
Surface conflict often hides deeper problems.

Step 3 | Bring Them Together
Neutral space. Use “I feel” — not “You always.”

Step 4 | Find Common Ground
Focus on shared goals, not conflicting positions.

Step 5 | Agree on Solutions
Write it down. Set a follow-up date.

When Conflict Gets Serious

Some conflicts are beyond your capacity. Know when to escalate.

🚨 ESCALATE TO BOARD OR EXTERNAL HELP IF...

- ⚠️ Harassment, discrimination, or abuse allegations
- 🔁 Repeated policy violations despite warnings
- 🎯 Conflict directly involves you — you can't be neutral
- 💸 Financial fraud or theft
- 🔪 Threats or actual violence
- 📈 Problem escalated despite your intervention

RESOURCES:

- **Board of Directors**
- **HR Consultant / Lawyer**
- **Police**
- **Professional Mediator**

Activity: Ethical Dilemma Role-play

Apply ethical principles to real-world scenarios

Instructions:
In your groups of 4-5:

1. Review the scenario assigned to your group (e.g., 'The Late Report,' 'The Friend's Request,' or 'Leftover Money').
2. Discuss:
    - What is the core ethical problem here?
    - Who is affected by this decision?
    - What would you do as the leader?
3. Prepare a short 2-minute role-play to show your solution to the room.
    - Choose one person to be the "leader."
    - Others can play board members, friends, or staff.

Time: 15 minutes preparation | 2 minutes presentation per group

Discussion Questions:

- What made your decision challenging?
- How did you balance the mission of the organization with the personal pressure involved?
- Did your group use the principles of Disclose, Recuse, and Document?
- If you faced this situation again next year, would you do anything differently?

Your Deliverables

Submit to the YAN Digital Resource Platform

To complete this session, please submit the following:

1. Leadership Reflection Form
    - Submit your completed "Practical Exercise" answers (Your Strength + Skill to Improve).
2. Personal Leadership Charter
    - Write one paragraph (3-5 sentences) outlining:
        - Your core leadership values.
        - One key commitment to ethical practice in your organization.

Key Takeaways

1. Leadership ≠ Just having a title. It's about inspiring and serving others.
2. Know your structure: Board governs, Executive implements, Members participate.
3. Ethics aren't optional - integrity, transparency, safeguarding are foundational.
4. Communication is a skill you must practice daily - speaking AND listening.
5. Great facilitators create space for others to think, not impose their views.
6. Conflict is normal - address it early with empathy and clear processes.

Leadership is a journey, not a destination.
Keep learning, stay humble, and always put your mission first.

Now It’s Your Turn

This Week

Pick ONE thing to improve — safeguarding policy, active listening, or clarifying roles.

Remember

Great leaders are made, not born. You have everything you need.

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